

NEW TO AUSTRALIA

PAGE TITLE TAG: New to Australia? Complete Guide for New Arrivals 2026

META DESCRIPTION: Arrived in Australia or moving soon? Here's exactly what to do first — TFN, bank account, Medicare, housing — in the right order, from someone who did it in 2001.

SECTION 1 — HERO

Label: NEW TO AUSTRALIA GUIDE 2026

H1: Just Arrived in Australia? Here's Exactly What to Do First — and in the Right Order.

Intro: There is more information about moving to Australia online than you could read in a year. Government websites. Expat forums. Facebook groups with 40,000 members. YouTube channels. Reddit threads.

And yet almost every new arrival says the same thing in their first weeks: I had no idea where to start.

The problem was never a lack of information. The problem is that none of it is organised for your specific situation — your visa, your city, your profession, your family, your budget. The sequence that works for a UK nurse moving to Brisbane is completely different from the sequence that works for an Indian software engineer moving to Melbourne with a family of four.

“By the time most people realise they've taken the wrong steps in the wrong order, weeks have passed — and some of those mistakes are expensive to undo.”

Entel Dajsmaili, arrived January 2001. Australian citizen by 2004.

Primary CTA (Burnt Orange button): Get the Free 90-Day Arrival Checklist →

SECTION 2 — BEFORE YOU LAND

H2: Moving to Australia in 2026? Sort These Before Your Flight Lands

Documents to Carry Physically

- Passport + visa grant letter — printed, not just on your phone
- University offer letter or employment contract

- 3 months of bank statements from your home country
- International health insurance certificate
- 6 passport photos, you'll need them more than you expect

Book Before You Land

- **Short-term accommodation — minimum 4 weeks.** You need time to find a suburb that actually fits your life before you sign a 12-month lease. → Browse short-term accommodation in Australia
- **Airport transfer** — don't rely on Uber on arrival if you have heavy luggage and no Australian SIM yet
- **Travel insurance** for the gap before Medicare activates → [Cigna Global] or [SafetyWing](#)

Pro tip: Need short-term accommodation while you find your feet? I always recommend booking at least 3–4 weeks before committing to a suburb. Search by distance to your workplace first not by price or city centre. [referral link]

SECTION 3 — DOS AND DON'TS

H2: Australia Immigration Dos and Don'ts — Things That Most New Arrivals Get Wrong

DOS

Use your employer as a rental reference. You have no Australian rental history that's the reality for every new arrival. An employment contract plus a letter from your manager replaces rental references with most private landlords. Target private landlords over large real estate agencies. They have more flexibility and fewer box-ticking requirements.

Track your superannuation from week one. Every Australian employer is legally required to contribute 11% of your salary into a superannuation fund on top of your salary, not from it. Most migrants only find out years later that a previous employer didn't pay it. The ATO has a free tool to check. Use it from the start.

Build your Australian credit score deliberately from month one. Your overseas credit history means nothing here. You start at zero and that affects post-paid phone plans, car financing, and eventually a mortgage. A secured credit card linked to your bank account, used for small purchases and paid off in full every month, is the fastest way to build it.

DON'Ts

Don't sign a 24-month phone plan before you know your suburb. Go prepaid first. Coverage and pricing vary significantly depending on where you end up living. Lock yourself into a plan on day one and you may be paying for coverage you don't get where you actually live.

Don't ignore your superannuation even if you plan to leave. If you leave Australia permanently, you are legally entitled to claim your super back. It's called the Departing Australia Superannuation Payment (DASP). Most migrants walk away, leaving thousands behind simply because they didn't know this existed. It does. Claim it.

Don't spend a long time without medical insurance: If your visa doesn't qualify you for Medicare immediately, you need private cover before you land. One unplanned emergency visit costs \$800–\$2,000 out of pocket without it. Don't arrive uncovered. → Get a Cigna quote

SECTION 4 — YOUR FIRST 7 DAYS

H2: What to Do When You Arrive in Australia — The Order That Actually Matters

Here's what no government website tells you: these steps depend on each other. Get the sequence wrong and you'll find yourself trying to rent a flat without a bank account, or applying for Medicare without a registered address. This is the order that works.

Step	What	Why the Order Matters
1	Get an Australian SIM card	You need an Australian number for every form, callback, and verification
2	Apply for your TFN (Tax File Number)	Takes up to 28 days. Start this before anything else. Your employer legally needs it.
3	Open a bank account	Most banks require your TFN, or at least proof you've applied
4	Set up Medicare (if eligible)	Requires your bank account for rebate deposits
5	Secure rental accommodation	Requires bank statements which require an active bank account
6	Register your address with the ATO	Requires a permanent address
7	Transfer your international funds	Do this after your Australian account is active not before

"Most people try to rent first and open a bank account second. That's backwards. Without an Australian bank account you have no transaction history and agents will reject your application. Get the bank account first, even if you're still in temporary accommodation." Entel Dajsmaili

Day 1–2 — Get a SIM Card

Your Australian mobile number is the key that unlocks everything else. Every form, every callback, every bank verification uses it. Get one before you do anything else.

Go prepaid — Woolworths Mobile runs on Telstra towers at a fraction of the price. Don't sign a 24-month plan before you know your suburb and what coverage you actually get there.

Day 2–3 — Apply for Your TFN

Go to ato.gov.au right now. The application takes 20 minutes. Your TFN card arrives by post within 28 days however, you get a receipt number immediately, and most employers accept that.

Don't wait for the physical card before telling your employer you've applied. Without a TFN on file, you'll be taxed at 45% on everything you earn until you provide one.

Day 3–4 — Open Your Australian Bank Account

Two options that work for new arrivals with no Australian credit history:

Commonwealth Bank — you can open an account before you land, using just your passport. Walk into any branch on arrival to activate it. Your card is waiting.

Airwallex — no monthly fees, built for people moving money internationally. Good option if you're receiving payments from overseas or need multi-currency access.

→ [Open an Airwallex account] (*affiliate*)

Day 5 — Enrol in Medicare

Not every visa qualifies, and some have a waiting period. Check your visa conditions at homeaffairs.gov.au before you go. Take your passport and visa grant letter; you will need both. Show up without one, and they'll turn you away.

Day 6–7 — Set Up International Transfers

Your Australian bank charges 3–5% on every international transfer, buried inside the exchange rate. You won't see it on the confirmation screen it's hidden in the rate they give you.

Wise shows you the exact fee before you confirm the transfer. I've used it for years. On a \$5,000 transfer, the difference between using your bank and using Wise can be \$150–\$300.

→ [See current Wise rates] (*affiliate*)

SECTION 5 — FAQ

H2: New to Australia — Common Questions Answered

Do I need a TFN before I start working in Australia? No, you can legally start work without one. But apply the day you arrive. Without a TFN on file, your employer will tax you at 45% on everything you earn until you provide it. The online application takes 20 minutes at ato.gov.au.

Can I open an Australian bank account before I arrive? Yes. Commonwealth Bank allows you to open an account online up to 12 months before you arrive, using your passport. Your card will be waiting at a branch when you land. This is one of the most useful things you can do before you fly.

Does Medicare cover dental? No, and this surprises almost everyone. Medicare covers GP visits, public hospital stays, and partial specialist costs. Dental, optical, and physiotherapy are not covered. Budget for these separately, or look at private health insurance that includes extras cover.

How long does it take to get permanent residency in Australia? It depends on your visa pathway. Employer-sponsored (482 → 186): typically 2–4 years. Skilled independent (189 points-tested): 6 months to 2 years from invitation. Family/partner visa: 1–3 years. State nomination can speed up a skilled application significantly.

Can I rent a property in Australia without a local rental history? Yes. Offer to pay 4 weeks' rent in advance instead of 2. Use your employer as a character reference. Target private landlords over large real estate agencies they have more flexibility. Get a rental reference letter from your previous landlord overseas, translated into English if needed.

What happens to my superannuation if I leave Australia permanently? You can claim it back. It's called the Departing Australia Superannuation Payment (DASP). You apply online through the ATO after your visa expires and you've left the country. Tax is withheld on the payment, but you receive the balance. Most migrants leave thousands behind simply because they don't know this process exists.